

ART & CULTURE



PUPPETRY & MARTIAL ARTS

MODULE - 3

MARTIAL ARTS

MARTIAL ART IN INDIA

7

MARDANI KHEL



- 1 This is a traditional **Maharashtrian** armed martial art, which is practiced widely in the district of **Kolhapur**.
- 2 Mardani Khel focuses primarily on skills of weaponry, especially swords, swift movements and use of low stances that is suited to its originating place, the hill ranges.
- 3 It is known for the **use of the unique Indian Pata (sword) and Vita (corded lance)**.

MARTIAL ART IN INDIA

8

LATHI



1 An ancient armed martial art form of the country, **Lathi** also denote one of the world's oldest weapons used in martial arts.

2 **Lathi** refers to a 'stick' (usually cane sticks), which is generally 6 to 8 feet in length and sometimes metal tipped.

3 Indian police can be seen using such Lathis to control crowd.

4 Majorly practiced in **Punjab and Bengal**, it still is one of the popular sport in villages of the country.

MARTIAL ART IN INDIA

9

THODA

1 Originating in the state of **Himachal Pradesh**, Thoda is a mixture of martial arts, sport and culture.

2 It takes place during **Baisakhi** (13th and 14th April) every year.

3 A number of community prayers are done so as to invoke the blessings of **Goddesses Mashoo and Durga**, the principal deities.

4 The game is quite popular in various parts of the state including Narkanda block, Theong division (Shimla district), Chopal division, Solan and Sirmaur district.

5 Thoda can be dated back to **Mahabharata**, the times when bows and arrows were used in the epic battle, in the valleys of Kullu and Manali. Hence, **Thoda finds its genesis in Kullu**.

MARTIAL ART IN INDIA

9

THODA

6 The martial art relies on a **player's skill of archery**.



7 Its name is derived from the round wooden piece attached to the head of an arrow to minimize its lethal potential.

8 The equipment required for this game, i.e. wooden bows and arrows, are prepared by **traditional skilled artisans**.

9 The bows range from 1.5 to 2 meters, depending on the height of the archer. The arrows are in proportion to the bow.

MARTIAL ART IN INDIA

9

THODA



10 In the game, there are two groups of roughly 500 people each.

11 Most of these are **not archers but dancers who come along to boost the morale** of their respective teams.

12 The game is played in a marked court so as to ensure a certain degree of discipline.

13 The two teams are called **Pashis and Saathis**, who are believed to be the descendants of Pandavas and Kauravas of Mahabharata.

14 The archers aim for the leg, below the knee, as there are **negative points for striking any other parts of the body**.

10

GATKA



- 1 Gatka is a weapon based martial art form, performed by the Sikhs of Punjab.

- 2 Some say that the 'Gatka' comes from a Sanskrit word 'Gadha', which means mace.

- 3 Gatka features the skillful use of weapons, including stick, Kirpan, Talwar and Kataar.

- 4 The attack and defence in this art form is determined by the various positions of hands and feet and the nature of weapon used.

- 5 It is displayed on a number of celebrations in the state including fairs.

MARTIAL ART IN INDIA

11

INBUAN WRESTLING



1 A native martial art form of **Mizoram**, Inbuan Wrestling is believed to have its genesis in 1750 A.D. in Dungtland village.

2 It has very strict rules that prohibit stepping out of the circle, kicking and knee bending.

3 The way to win this is by lifting the opponent off their feet, while stringently adhering to the rulers.

4 It also involves catching of the belt (worn around their waist) by the wrestlers.

5 This art form was regarded as a sport **only after the people of Mizoram migrated from Burma to Lushai hills.**

MARTIAL ART IN INDIA

12

MUSTI YUDDHA



- 1 Originated in oldest city of the country, **Varnasi**, Musti Yuddha is an **unarmed** martial art form.
- 2 It used techniques like kicks, punches, knee and elbow strikes.
- 3 Although rarely visible now, it was quite a popular art during 1960s.
- 4 Musti Yuddha incorporated the development of all three aspects, **physical, mental and spiritual**.

MARTIAL ART IN INDIA

13

MALLA YUDDHA



- 1 Malla Yuddha is the traditional form of combat-wrestling practiced in South India and is related to various other Southeast Asian wrestling styles like Naban

- 2 The fights in this art are divided into four categories and are **named according to the Hindu Gods** that excelled that particular kind of art form.
- 3 The first one is called **Jambuvanti** that refers to the forcing the opponent into submission through locking and holding.
- 4 The second is **Hanumanti**, which is for technical superiority.
- 5 The third refers to **Bhimaseni**, which focuses on sheer strength while the last one is called **Jarasandhi** that concentrates on limb and joint breaking.

MARTIAL ART IN INDIA

NAME OF THE ART	PLACE OF ORIGIN	DESCRIPTION
Paika Akhadha	Odisha	A combination of dance and combat. Earlier used by warriors, now practiced as a performing art.
Sqay	Kashmir	Use of swords and shields
Kathi Samu	Andhra Pradesh	Ancient skill mastered by royal armies of the state
Bandesh	India	The philosophy of this ancient martial art is interesting and notable. This ancient unarmed art uses various lock holds against an armed opponent without killing them.

ART & CULTURE



PUPPETRY & MARTIAL ARTS

NOTES ON INDIAN CIRCUS

INDIAN CIRCUS



- 1 India has a long tradition of street performers and artists who would go from town to town.
- 2 However, circus in the modern sense of the term is fairly a new industry.
- 3 According to Philip Astley, a English circus master, the first Indian Circus was born around 1880.

INDIAN CIRCUS

THE GREAT INDIAN CIRCUS



VISHNUPANT CHATRE

FACT FOR EXAM!

The year 2020 will be the 140th year anniversary of circus in India.

- 1 The Great Indian Circus was the first modern Indian circus, founded by Vishnupant Chatre, an accomplished equestrian and singer.
- 2 It flourished under the patronage of the Rajah of Kurduwadi, under whom Chatre worked as a stable master.
- 3 The first performance of The Great Indian Circus was held on March 20, 1880, following which it toured extensively throughout the country as well as in foreign shores such as Ceylon and South East Asia.
- 4 He gained appreciation everywhere.

INDIAN CIRCUS

KEELERI KUNHIKANAN



KEELERI KUNHIKANAN

- 1 Back in India, Chatre met Keeleri Kunhikanan during his tour in the city of **Thalassery** on the Malabar Coast.

- 2 Keeleri Kunhikanan worked as a **martial art and gymnastics teacher**.
- 3 On Chatre's insistence, **Keeleri** started **training acrobats** at his academy.
- 4 In 1901, he opened the first circus school at Kolam, which became the epicentre of the circus revolution in India.
- 5 In 1904, one of Kunhikanan's students, **Pariyali Kannan** started his own circus company by the name of **Grand Malabar Circus**.

INDIAN CIRCUS

KEELERI KUNHIKANAN



The Great Indian Circus

- 6 Other companies such as White Way Circus (1922), Great Rayman Circus (1924), The Great Lion Circus, the Eastern Circus, the Fairy Circus, etc. were started by the students of Kunhikanan
- 7 Thus, Kerala came to be known as the 'Cradle of Indian Circus'.
- 8 Kunhikanan's academy also gave rise to a number of acrobats who gained national and international claim.

INDIAN CIRCUS

MAJOR CIRCUS COMPANIES IN INDIA

Even though Indian Circus companies failed to compete with American and European competitors, nonetheless, they remained a major source of entertainment for the Indian masses till the late 1990s.

MAJOR INDIAN CIRCUSES



1

Gemini Circus

- In 1964, Gemini Circus became the first Indian circus to delegate at the **International Circus Festival in USSR**.
- They held shows at Moscow, Sochi and Yalta.
- Gemini Circus also became the backdrop of many Indian movies such as Raj Kapoor's "*Mera Naam Joker*".

INDIAN CIRCUS

MAJOR CIRCUS COMPANIES IN INDIA

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MAJOR INDIAN CIRCUSES

2

Jumbo Circus

It is “The Pride of India” and is the largest Indian Circus of modern times.



3

Great Royal Circus



INDIAN CIRCUS

MAJOR CIRCUS COMPANIES IN INDIA

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MAJOR INDIAN CIRCUSES

4

Three Ring Circus

K. Damodaran was instrumental in starting this circus.



5

Great Bombay Circus



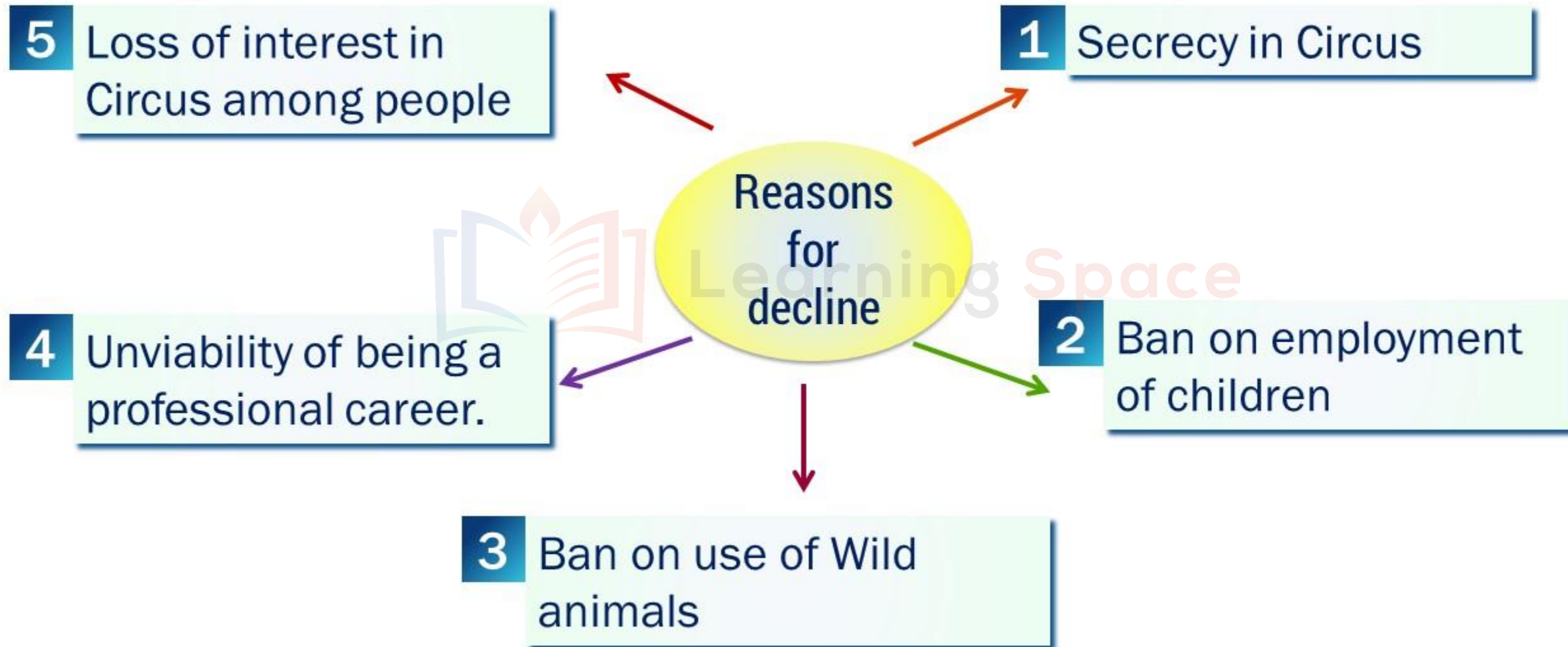
PRACTICE QUESTIONS – MAINS

- 1 Circus Industry in India has become a marginal Industry. Suggest the measures in this regard?
- 2 Write a brief note on the Circus Industry in India.



INDIAN CIRCUS

CIRCUS : A MARGINAL INDUSTRY



INDIAN CIRCUS

CIRCUS : A MARGINAL INDUSTRY

Since the late 90s, circus industry has dwindled and declined owing to a variety of reasons. While there were around 300 Indian circuses in 1990, the number has come down to just 30 in 2014.



REASONS FOR DECLINE

- 1 Indian Circus companies try to keep their **trade a guarded secret**. This has made it a **hereditary affair** and kept it in the confines of a select few. This has prevented good managers from entering the circus business.
- 2 The Indian circus companies feel that circus acrobatics **require intensive training from childhood**. With the Supreme Court's ban on hiring children below the age of 14 in 2011, this **limited the resource pool of the circus companies**.

INDIAN CIRCUS

CIRCUS : A MARGINAL INDUSTRY

REASONS FOR DECLINE

3 With the Government of India enforcing ban on the use of wild animals for the purpose of entertainment, a typical genre of performance and attraction for the audience ceased to exist.



4 With access to world class gymnastics and other forms of e-entertainment, the younger generation has lost interest in the traditional Indian circus. The circus companies also failed to match up to their competition.



INDIAN CIRCUS

CIRCUS : A MARGINAL INDUSTRY

REASONS FOR DECLINE



- 5 Among the Indian masses, circus is generally seen as a dangerous profession.
- 6 So, families are unwilling to let their children choose it as a viable professional career.
- 7 This has also prevented the development of dynasties of circus performers, unlike in the west.

INDIAN CIRCUS

POSSIBLE REMEDIES



- 1 An increased emphasis on the safety regulations and strict enforcing of the same would help in improving the perception of circus as a career opportunity.
- 2 Circus can be used to promote the dying arts among the masses. This would also increase its attraction quotient.
- 3 Government protection for the circus performers and the companies would also help in reviving the dying industry.

INDIAN CIRCUS

POSSIBLE REMEDIES



युवा कार्यक्रम और खेल मंत्रालय

MINISTRY OF

YOUTH AFFAIRS AND SPORTS



सत्यमेव जयते

Ministry of Culture

Government of India

REFERENCE ARTICLE

“Circus is trying to regain its lost sheen in Thalassery” : ECONOMIC TIMES

4 Most artists retire by the age of 40, after which they have to work as manual labours. **Security and compensation** for them is a necessity.

5 Presently circuses are under the ambit of the **Department of Sports and Youth Affairs**.

6 Bringing it under the **Ministry of Culture** would help in a better strategizing of its revival.

7 It would also be an **acknowledgement of circus as an art form**.

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